

Automarkt in China

Autoverkäufe in China brechen ein - droht eine Trendwende?

China gilt als Zugpferd für Autoverkäufe, doch seit einigen Monaten gehen die Absatzzahlen deutlich zurück. Experten sind sich uneins, wie es weitergeht. Was bedeutet der Trend für deutsche Autobauer?

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The headline says the market is breaking.

Most readings get it wrong.

What the number hides, and why it lands on Europe's

READ THE NUMBER CORRECTLY

-22% CPCA retail
end-customer sales, May YoY

-2% CAAM total
incl. wholesale, commercial, exports

Same month. Two very different stories. And last year was a strong base. This is a sharp drop from a high level, not a market falling off a cliff.

NEVs passed 60% of retail. Partly an **optical illusion.**

The share rises not only because EVs boom, but because combustion is collapsing underneath them. ICE sales fell far faster than the market.

Once buyers feel how exposed a petrol car is to a fuel-price shock, the shift is a one-way street.

“Exports are a valve,
not a lifeline.”

Outbound shipments are surging and becoming the new driver. But at home there is overcapacity and a price war the leaders pay for with record discounts and thinning margins.

Chinese executives already call it an **elimination phase**.

Key markets are pushing for local production.

- Europe
- South America
- Russia
- India

Each one that localises closes the easy exit. EU tariffs and a proposed overcapacity instrument slow it. They do not stop it.

“Export buys Chinese makers air. It carries the brutal price war directly to our doorstep.”

The pressure on European OEMs is not gone. It is delayed. Reading a 22% drop as breathing room gets the dynamic exactly backwards.

SO WHAT FOR GERMAN MAKERS

China stopped being a growth market in a few short years.

German premium brands now face sales last seen a decade ago. Where they once led segments for years, Chinese groups set the tone.

<10% German brands' combined share of China's pure-EV market

Where the music plays, Germany is barely present.

The right answer is already visible: radical localisation.

To survive in China, you have to develop in China.
The era when German engineering alone was enough is over for good.

The old logic, designed in Germany, built in China, no longer works.

Speed, software and price are now defined **in China**.

But localisation tightens a **pincer.**

Beijing pushes digitalisation and demands makers plug deeper into a data-driven ecosystem, trading efficiency against handing over sensitive data and technology.

German OEMs produce in China, sell in China, export from China. They can least afford an open EU-China trade war.